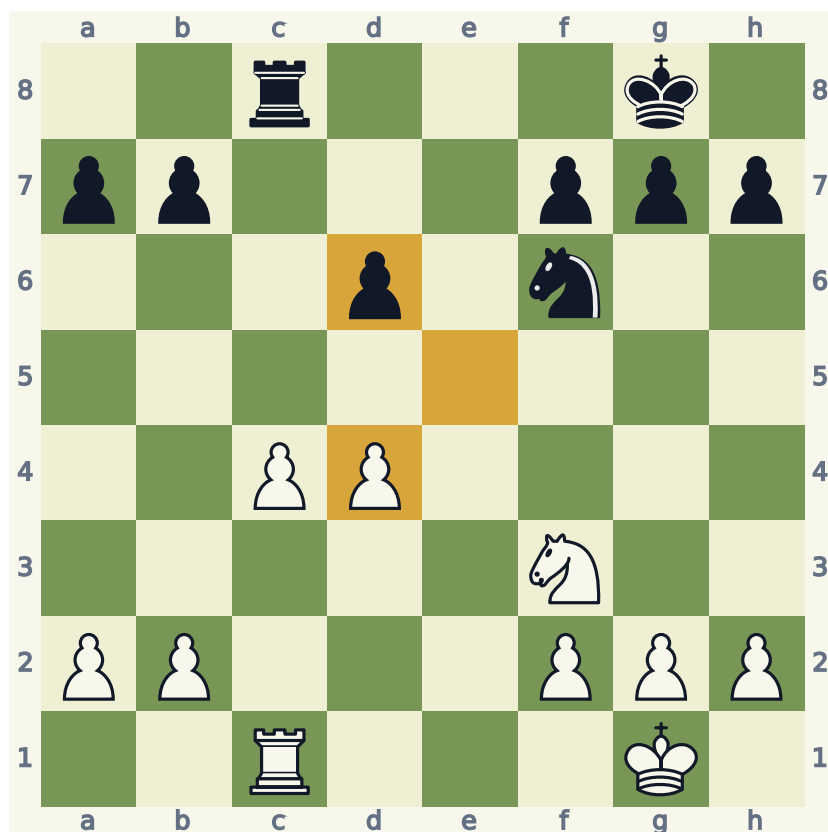


Weak squares and outposts

A strong square needs access, stability and purpose.

An outpost is a useful advanced square where a piece can operate without being driven away by an enemy pawn. Pawn support helps, but support alone is not enough. Ask whether you can reach the square, whether pieces can exchange you, and what the occupant will actually attack or restrict.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- d4 supports e5, making the square look attractive.
- But Black's d6-pawn attacks e5.
- A pawn-supported square is not automatically an outpost.

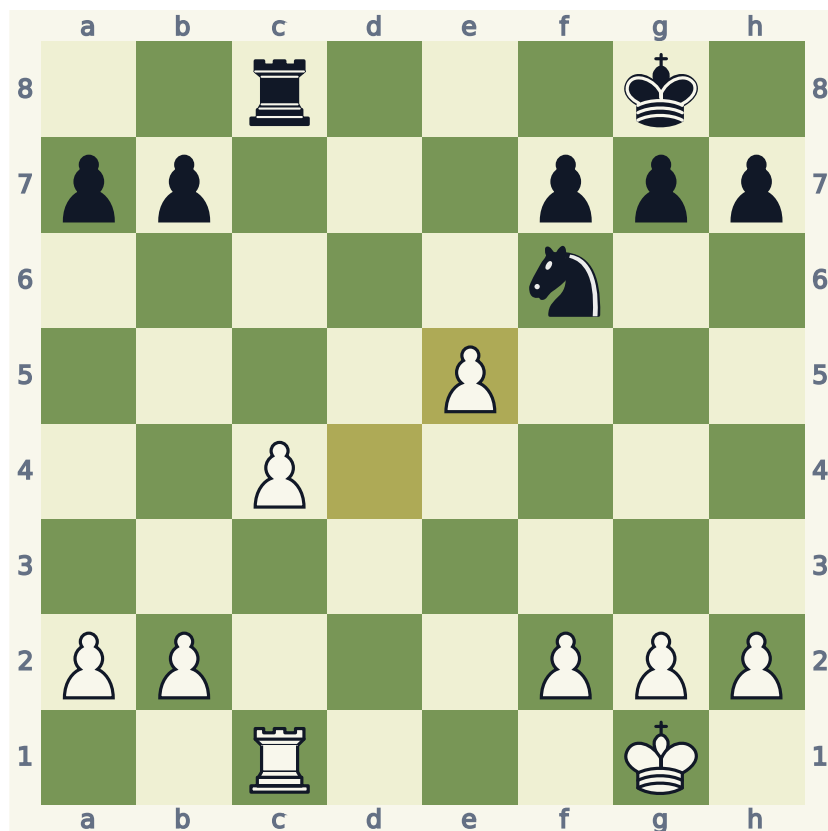
REMEMBER

- Check present and future pawn attacks.
- Prove a safe route to the square.
- Name the occupant's useful targets.

Follow the logic

1. Ne5 dxe5 2. dxe5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Ne5?

This is the deliberately flawed candidate. The knight lands on a square controlled by a lower-value enemy pawn.

...dxe5

Black captures it. Strategic language cannot compensate for losing a piece without sufficient return.

dxe5

White regains the pawn but has traded a knight for a pawn. The square was supported, yet not secure.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

To establish an outpost, White would first need to remove or deflect the pawn that controls the square, or choose a different destination. Black should preserve useful pawn control when practical.

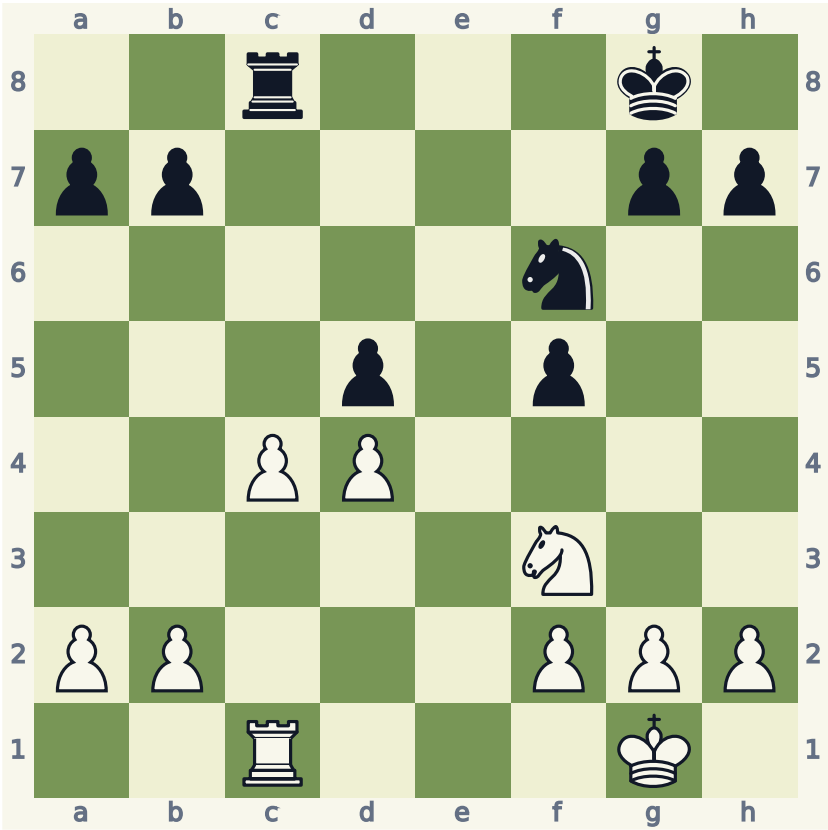
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

A hole is not necessarily exploitable. If no piece can reach it or the occupant has no useful targets, the square may have little practical value.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Why is e5 more stable in this version?
- 2. Which white pawn supports the knight?
- 3. Name one useful effect of Ne5 and one remaining limitation.

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If Black's f-pawn were still on f7 instead, how would that change e5?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 2r3k1/pp4pp/5n2/3p1p2/2PP4/5N2/PP3PPP/2R3K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Black's d- and f-pawns are already on d5 and f5. They control e4 and cannot retreat to d6 or f6 to challenge e5. This makes e5 a stable outpost against pawn attacks in this structure.
2. The pawn on d4 protects e5. If Black exchanges this supporting pawn, the knight's stability must be assessed again. Structural support and the enemy's future pawn breaks belong in the same calculation.
3. Ne5 centralizes the knight and gives it access to c6, d7, f7 and g6. It also defends c4. Black can still seek a piece exchange or attack d4 to undermine the support; stable against pawns does not mean impossible to exchange.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Ne5 Kf8

Changed feature: Black could consider ...f6 to attack e5. The knight might still be useful there, but its occupation would no longer be secure against pawn challenges.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Circle three potential outposts in a game. Reject any square that can be challenged by a realistic pawn advance, then explain the value of those remaining.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 02, 12, 19. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.